

Cheat sheets — the final 48 hours

Five sheets, one per paper. Each fits a printed page.

This is not for learning. Everything here is taught properly in the chapters — these are the pages you read when you are too anxious to read prose.

1 • LISTENING

40 questions • 1 mark each • ~30 min • played ONCE • no negative marking

Band	Marks
6	23–25
6.5	26–29
7	30–31
7.5	32–34

From the top of 6.5 to band 7 is ONE mark.

The four rules that pay

1. **One answer per gap.** Two scores zero even when one is right.
2. **Never a blank.** No negative marking. Guess the right *type* of word.
3. **Obey the word limit exactly.** Three words under a two-word limit = zero. Articles and prepositions count; hyphenated words are one.
4. **Answers come in order — every question type.** Miss one, go forward. Hunting backwards turns one lost mark into three.

Predict before every gap

Type of word • singular or plural • two candidate answers. "*The library closes at _____*" can only take a time.

The traps

- Option mentioned **then rejected** — *we did consider Thursday, but...*
- Correction **after** — *sorry, I mean...* → the answer follows
- Contrast **before** — *just €6, down from the usual €9.50* → the answer leads
- *proposed* ≠ *actual* • *modern* ≠ *recently opened*
- The item **missing** from a printed list is the answer

Spelling

American spellings **accepted**. Capitalisation doesn't matter. But *informations, researches, advices* are **zeros** — in Listening your writing errors are the whole mark, not a criterion.

 **No transfer time. 2 minutes to check** — spelling and plurals only.

Walking in: *type it right the first time. There is no tidying-up phase.*

2 • READING

3 passages • 40 questions • 60 min • NO transfer time • no negative marking

	Band	Marks
	6	23–26
	6.5	27–29
	7	30–32

Reading is harder than Listening at the same raw score. 26 marks is 6.5 in Listening and still 6 in Reading.

The clock is the skill

About **20 minutes per passage**. Hard stops. Obey them mid-question. Overrunning Passage 1 by ten minutes to win two marks costs five in Passage 3.

Order

Matching Headings **early** — it maps the passage. Matching Information **last** — slowest, answers not in order.

True/False/Not Given — the one that decides your band

Ask: can I point at the sentence that contradicts this?

- **Yes** → FALSE
- **No** → NOT GIVEN
- Stated in different words → TRUE

A scope mismatch is usually NOT GIVEN. Passage gives a figure for *managerial staff*, statement says *all employees* → the passage never spoke about the wider group. That is a **gap**, not a contradiction. Only FALSE when the passage *does* address it and goes the other way — *only in coastal regions* vs *nationwide*.

Never use outside knowledge. Never reflex-guess Not Given — decide from what you read.

 **Copy-paste from the passage** into completion answers. Spelling errors become impossible. **CTRL+F does not work.**

Walking in: *the answer is never in the question's words. Hunt the idea.*

3 • WRITING TASK 1

≥150 words • 20 min • one third of the Writing band

The clock

0:00–0:05	Read, spot the pattern, decide the grouping
0:05–0:17	Write
0:17	Stop writing
0:17–0:20	Check

Four paragraphs

1. **Intro** — one sentence, paraphrase the prompt
2. **Overview** — 2–3 sentences, **no numbers**, the big patterns. *Overall,...*
3. **Body 1** — one group, with figures
4. **Body 2** — the rest

No conclusion. No opinions. No causes.

The two things that cap Task Achievement

- **No overview** → capped.
- **Listing instead of grouping** → band 7 requires the data *appropriately categorised*. Walking along the x-axis is band 6 **by the wording**.

Before you stop

Overview present? • ≥150 words (after subtracting anything copied)? • figures and units right? • grouped not listed? • tense right? • no opinion?

Copied rubric is discounted before your words are counted. Copying the chart title is the commonest silent way under 150.

Walking in: *decide the grouping before you write a word. Everything follows from it.*

4 • WRITING TASK 2

≥250 words • 40 min • WORTH DOUBLE TASK 1

The clock

0:00–0:05	Underline every part of the question. Plan.
0:05–0:37	Write
0:37	Stop writing
0:37–0:40	Check — delete and repair, never add

Structure

Intro (position stated) → Body 1 → Body 2 → Conclusion (no new ideas)

Target 260–290. There is a floor and no ceiling — an official 7.5 script runs to ~375 words. Write as long as you can write *accurately*.

The one thing that separates 6 from 7

Develop, don't assert.

| *claim* → **because** → **so what** → *concrete instance*

Band 6 states ideas. Band 7 extends them.

The killers, in order

1. A question part unanswered → "**If you don't discuss both, you will be limited to Band 5**" (official)
2. Undeveloped paragraphs — claims with no reasoning
3. Memorised openers — *In this contemporary era of globalisation...*
4. Linker spam — **two discourse markers per paragraph is the ceiling**
5. Thesaurus abuse — the wrong rare word scores **below** the right common one

Hedge, don't overgeneralise

tend to · in most cases · are likely to · appears to be This is credited as higher-level lexis **and** defuses the band-7 "tendency to over-generalise". It costs nothing and uses words you already own.

Under length has no published penalty — it costs you through Task Response and reduced evidence of range.

| **Walking in:** *answer every part of the question. Nothing else costs as much.*

5 • SPEAKING

11–14 min · 3 parts · four equal criteria

Part 1 — 4–5 min

Answer + reason + example. Two or three sentences. Never one word.

Part 2 — 1 min prep, speak 1–2 min

Prep minute = **keywords, not sentences.** Reading aloud flattens delivery. **Speak the full two minutes.** Being stopped **means you spoke long enough.** Invent freely — nobody verifies your story.

Part 3 — 4–5 min — where band 7 is decided

Expect pushback. It is a test, not hostility. **Concede, then hold your ground with a reason.**

It's likely that... · That's true up to a point, but... · Compared with a generation ago... · Broadly speaking...

Pronunciation — in this order

1. **Slow down.** A rapid speech rate is named at band 6 as damaging rhythm.
2. **Stress-timing.** English compresses unstressed syllables. Arabic and French don't. Your cheapest route out of 6.
3. **Chunking** — pause at sense boundaries, not mid-phrase.
4. Word stress — resist French final-syllable stress.

Your accent costs nothing. The descriptor mentions accent only at bands 8 and 9, and only to say it has minimal or no effect.

Two things to stop worrying about

- **Hesitation.** Band 7 hesitation *is* language-related and mid-sentence. It only must not break your coherence. Content-only hesitation is band 8.
- **Small grammar slips.** Bands 7 *and* 8 both allow a few basic errors to persist. Make complex sentences **land**; don't chase every **-s**.

Don't know a word? **Paraphrase.** That is band 7, not failure.

Walking in: *slow down, and answer the question you were actually asked.*

The arithmetic, once

Overall = mean of four, rounded to the nearest half band. .25 rounds up to the next half band. .75 rounds up to the next whole band.

You do not need 7 everywhere:

L	R	W	S	Reported
7.5	7.5	6.0	6.5	7.0
7.0	7.0	6.5	6.5	7.0
6.5	6.5	6.5	6.5	6.5 ✗

From a 6.5 floor in all four, you need **two more half-bands** — not four sevens.